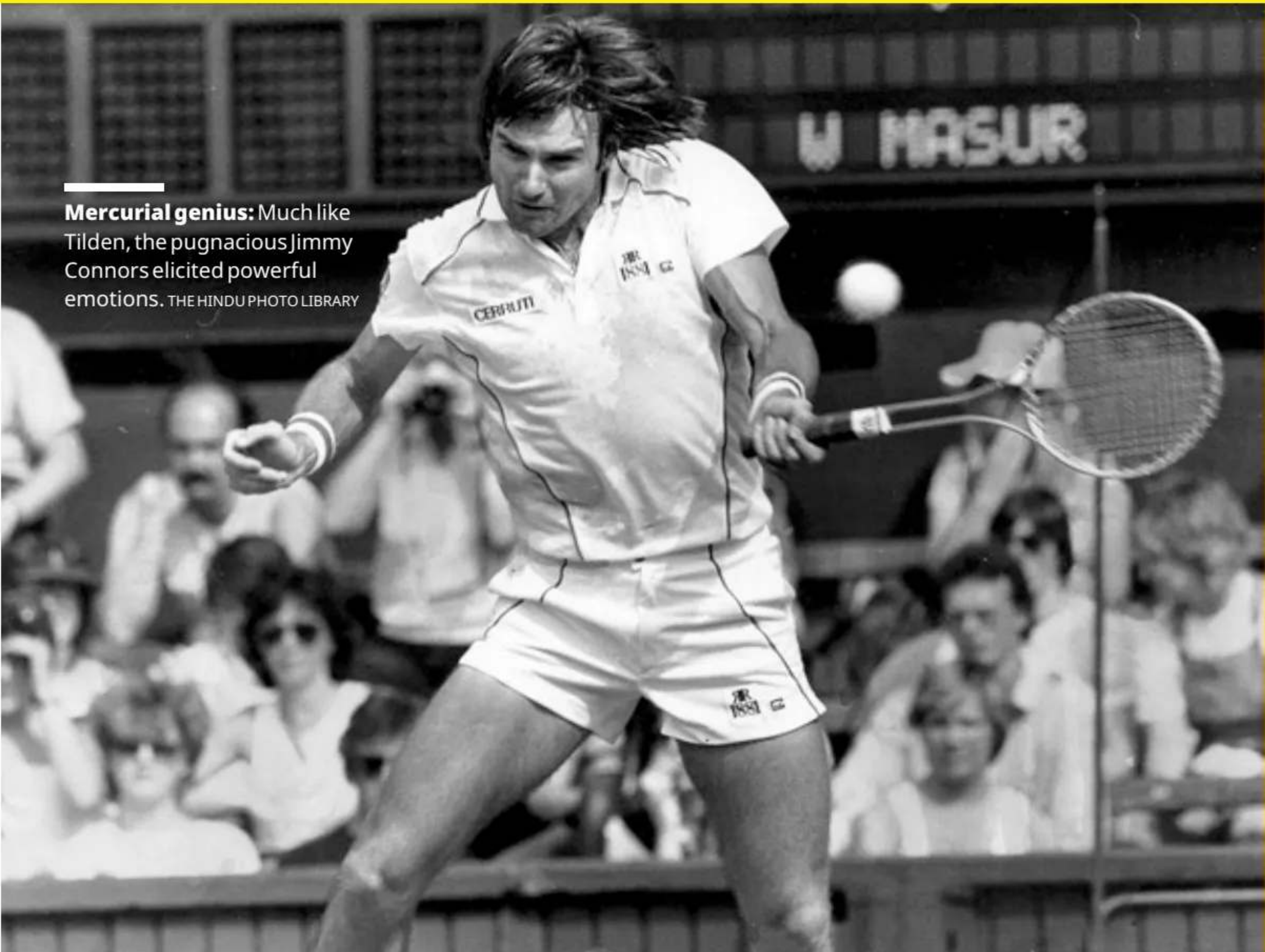




Mercurial genius: Much like Tilden, the pugnacious Jimmy Connors elicited powerful emotions. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

larger-than-life 1920s superstar, was renowned for intentionally falling behind inferior opponents in early-round matches. As cries of “Tilden’s in trouble!” spread, spectators scurried to see him pull off another theatrical comeback. In another party trick, the imperious American held five balls in his massive hand, fired four straight aces to win a game, and then casually tossed the fifth ball into the stands. “Tilden always seems to have a thousand means of putting the ball away from his opponent’s reach. He seems to exercise a strange fascination over his opponent as well as the spectators,” wrote archrival Rene Lacoste in his 1928 book, *Lacoste on Tennis*.

Tilden’s passion to perform and his love of the dramatic arts made him a natural for Hollywood’s fast-growing silent film industry. The sports hero drew mixed reviews as an actor. After playing a ‘pseudo tramp’ in the

Broadway comedy, *They All Want Something*, the *New York Times* reviewer wrote that it was “at best only moderately entertaining” and had “none of the vitality he shows on the tennis courts.” But the *New York Journal* review said that the budding thespian “moved with all the grace and stage presence of a seasoned actor.” Bill also became a playwright and producer, sometimes investing in his creations.

Much like Tilden, the pugnacious Connors elicited powerful emotions. Reviled in the 1970s for being rude, crude, and lewd — even mimicking masturbation — on the court, Jimbo was revered in the 1980s. Fist pumping — which he claimed he invented in tennis, animalistic grunts, powerful two-handed backhands, the Jimmy Cagney strut, and repartee with spectators make this rebel without a pause can’t-miss TV for the sporting masses. Connors’s rivalries with the stoical

Bjorn Borg, irascible John McEnroe, and dour Ivan Lendl provided riveting, high-stake matches, as did his 1975 Wimbledon final against Arthur Ashe. But his fiery competitiveness was never more appreciated than at age 39 during his comeback victory — he trailed 5-2 in the fifth set — over Aaron Krickstein, 15 years his junior, in the 1991 US Open quarterfinals. After belting a winner, the ageless warrior yelled toward a court microphone, “This is what they came for! This is what they want!”

On five-time winner Connors’s love affair with the boisterous US Open fans, Chris Evert, his former fiancée, told *USTA Magazine*, “No one ever made a tennis court come alive more.”

An artist with a racquet

John McEnroe, another fiery, Irish American lefty, said the compliment he relished most during his halcyon